被降级的冥王星

The Planet That Was Demoted



冥王星本身没变，为什么会失去行星身份？

英文原文

On 18 February 1930, comparing **photographic** plates at the Lowell Observatory, the **astronomer** Clyde Tombaugh **perceived** a **dim dot** that shifted between them. An eleven-year-old English girl **put forward** the name, after the Roman **deity** of the **underworld**. For 76 years Pluto held the ninth **slot** on the **planetary roster**.

In January 2005, astronomers found a **far-off** body, later named Eris, at first thought larger than Pluto. NASA briefly called it the tenth planet. The **contender** posed an **awkward dilemma**. The term "planet" had **hitherto** been used **loosely**, and with more **icy** worlds likely to be found, a **precise definition** became a **necessity**.

On 24 August 2006 the International Astronomical Union, **convened** in Prague, voted that a planet must **revolve around** the Sun, be nearly **spherical**, and have cleared the **neighbourhood** around its orbit. Pluto failed that last **criterion** and was **reclassified as** a **dwarf** planet, leaving eight. Pluto was **physically unaltered**; only the **boundary** had moved.

The vote was **valid**, yet its **legitimacy** drew **criticism**: only 424 of some 10,000 members took part. Hundreds of **dissenting** astronomers signed a **petition**. The American Dialect Society made "plutoed", **playful slang** for "to **devalue**", its word of 2006, and New Mexico and Illinois **lawmakers** passed **resolutions affirming** that Pluto was a planet.

Amid the **controversy**, an **irony** was already **in transit**. New Horizons was launched on 19 January 2006, seven months before the vote, carrying **a pinch of** Tombaugh's ashes. On 14 July 2015 the **unmanned** craft flew past Pluto, **transmitting** images of an **enormous heart-shaped** plain, **fittingly** named Tombaugh Regio. The **discoverer**'s ashes **swept past** the heart that bears his name.

中文译文

1930年2月18日，在洛厄尔天文台比对照相底片时，天文学家克莱德·汤博察觉到一个暗淡的小点，它在底片之间移动过。一名11岁的英国女孩提议了它的名字，名字取自罗马神话中的冥界神灵。此后76年里，冥王星一直占据行星名单上的第九个位置。

2005年1月，天文学家发现了一个遥远的天体，它后来被命名为厄里斯，起初被认为比冥王星还要大。美国航天局曾短暂地称它为第十大行星。这个竞争者造成了一个尴尬的两难困境。“行星”一词此前一直被用得很不严谨/宽泛，而随着更多冰冷天体很可能被发现，一个精确的定义便成了必需。

2006年8月24日，国际天文学联合会在布拉格召开会议，投票决定：一颗行星必须围绕太阳转动、形状接近球形，并且已清空其轨道附近的区域。冥王星不符合最后一条标准，并被重新归类为矮行星，行星只剩下八颗。冥王星在物理上毫无改变，只有界线移动了。

这次表决虽然是有效的，但其正当性却招致了批评：约1万名成员中仅有424人参加。数百名持异议的天文学家签署了一份请愿书。美国方言学会把“plutoed”，这个戏谑的俚语，意思是“贬低”，评为2006年度词汇，而新墨西哥州和伊利诺伊州的立法者通过决议，确认冥王星是行星。

就在一片争议声中，一件颇具讽刺意味的事早已在途中。新视野号于2006年1月19日发射，比那次表决早七个月，携带着一小撮汤博的骨灰。2015年7月14日，这艘无人飞船飞掠过冥王星，传回了图像，图像上是一片巨大的心形平原，这片平原恰如其分地被命名为汤博区。这位发现者的骨灰掠过了那颗以他命名的心。

词汇与表达

photographic adj.
照相

astronomer n.
天文学家

perceived v.
察觉
perceived a dim dot

dim adj.
暗淡的

dot n.
小点

put forward phr.
提议了
put forward the name

deity n.
神灵

underworld n.
冥界

slot n.
位置

planetary adj.
行星

roster n.
名单

far-off adj.
遥远的

contender n.
竞争者
The contender posed an awkward dilemma

awkward adj.
尴尬的

dilemma n.
两难困境
an awkward dilemma

hitherto adv.
此前

loosely adv.
不严谨/宽泛

icy adj.
冰冷

precise adj.
精确的
a precise definition

definition n.
定义
a precise definition

necessity n.
必需
became a necessity

convened v.
召开会议
convened in Prague

revolve around v.
围绕……转动
revolve around the Sun

spherical adj.
球形
be nearly spherical

neighbourhood n.
区域

criterion n.
标准
that last criterion

词汇与表达（续）

reclassified as v.
重新归类为
reclassified as a dwarf planet

dwarf adj.
矮行星

physically adv.
物理上

unaltered adj.
毫无改变
Pluto was physically unaltered

boundary n.
界线
only the boundary had moved

valid adj.
有效的
The vote was valid

legitimacy n.
正当性
its legitimacy drew criticism

criticism n.
批评

dissenting adj.
持异议的
dissenting astronomers

petition n.
请愿书
signed a petition

playful adj.
戏谑的

slang n.
俚语

devalue v.
贬低

lawmakers n.
立法者

resolutions n.
决议

affirming v.
确认
affirming that Pluto was a planet

controversy n.
争议
Amid the controversy

irony n.
讽刺
an irony was already in transit

in transit n.
在途中

a pinch of n.
一小撮

unmanned adj.
无人

transmitting v.
传回了
transmitting images

enormous adj.
巨大的

heart-shaped adj.
心形

fittingly adv.
恰如其分地

discoverer n.
发现者

swept past phr.
掠过了

文章简述

- 发现：1930年，汤博发现冥王星。此后76年，人们一直把它列为太阳系第九颗行星。
- 重审：2005年发现厄里斯，起初以为它比冥王星还大；类似天体可能越来越多，天文学家需要说清什么才算行星。
- 改类：2006年新规要求行星绕太阳、接近球形，还要靠引力主导轨道周边区域。冥王星达不到最后一条，改列矮行星，太阳系行星剩八颗。
- 争议：这只是分类标准变了，冥王星本身没有变化。表决合乎程序，但约一万会员只有424人参与，决定的代表性受到质疑。
- 探访：2015年，新视野号带着少量汤博骨灰飞掠冥王星，传回一个以汤博命名的巨大心形区域的图像。